Sourav, with a number of lucky breaks going my way. I was dropped in the eighties and nineties and I told Sourav that God wanted me to score a century on the occasion of Sourav's farewell Test match.

In his final Test Sourav scored a valuable 85 for the team. We managed 441 in our first innings but I still felt we were 100 runs short. It was a good batting wicket and the Australians raced on in the last session of day two to finish at 189–2. We knew we could not afford to let them get away the next morning. We had to try something different to make them think and take some risks, because they were the ones under pressure to level the series. I suggested to Dhoni that we needed to slow down the game, and after that we employed an 8–1 field, with eight fielders on the off side and one on the on, something hardly ever tried in Test cricket, to Michael Hussey and Simon Katich, and despite dropping Katich early on we managed to restrict the runs. Zaheer and Ishant bowled well to the field and Australia just could not get away.

They added only 42 runs before lunch and Ishant also dismissed Simon Katich in the process. That wicket changed everything and we took a further three in the session between lunch and tea, conceding just 49 runs. The momentum had shifted and we knew we were back in control. We eventually set Australia a target of 382 in their second innings, and then Amit Mishra, the leg-spinner who had replaced Anil, and Harbhajan Singh finished things off midway through the second session on day five and we won the series 2–0.

The celebrations went on into the night and both Anil and Sourav were asked to give speeches. Gary, who had played a huge role behind the scenes, had organized the farewell at the VCA Club in Jamtha and it was a day everyone who was there will cherish for ever. The whole team stayed on in Nagpur for this very special occasion and I did the same, despite having to miss Anjali's fortieth birthday. I knew that, as always, she would understand and pardon my absence.

India in Sri Lanka 2008

1st Test. Colombo (SSC). 23–26 July 2008

Sri Lanka 600–6 dec (DPMD Jayawardene 136, TT Samaraweera 127, TM Dilshan 125*, SM Warnapura 115; I Sharma 2–124)

India 223 (VVS Laxman 56, **SR Tendulkar 27**; M Muralitharan 5–84, BAW Mendis 4–72) and 138 (f/o) (G Gambhir 43, **SR Tendulkar 12**; M Muralitharan 6–26, BAW Mendis 4–60)